

Composing: Drawing on Experience & Evidence

1. Responding to an Assignment

2. Freewriting

- Guided Reading: Gwen Ganow, Topic for the “Take a Position” Assignment: Superheroes and Social Attitudes

CHAPTER 4-A

Responding to an Assignment

All composing takes place within a rhetorical situation. Remember that genre is a social response to a rhetorical situation. In this chapter, we will follow one of Amy's former students, Gwen Ganow, as she composes in response to the rhetorical situation of an assignment in her writing course. Here is the assignment she was given, along with her annotations. (Note: It's a good idea to annotate an assignment to make sure you understand it and to help you think through the different steps.)

	Assignment: Take a Position Argue? Take a position on a topic you care about and have experience with. Then think about who you want to communicate your ideas to and compose in a genre that will allow you to do that. I get to pick the genre You may compose in any genre that seems appropriate for your purpose and audience. The length should be appropriate to the genre; in other words, a magazine article will have more words than a poster. Be sure to choose a genre that will allow you to communicate with the audience you have in mind. For sources, you should primarily draw upon your own experience. If you wish, you can use other source material if it is appropriate to your genre choice and topic. Movies, video games, outdoors, comics, animals? 1. Brainstorm potential topics you have experience with and could take a position on. 2. Select the topic you are most excited about and take a position. You might find freewriting useful to help you articulate your position. 3. Consider your rhetorical situation. You know your purpose is to take a position and try to convince others of its merit. Who are the others you are convincing? That is your audience. 4. What genres might that audience encounter? List three of them that would allow you to achieve your purpose and reach your audience. 5. Analyze and annotate examples of the three different genres that you are considering composing in, identifying the genre conventions. 6. Draft your genre piece. 7. Revise your genre piece. The genre I choose needs to respond to my purpose and audience. How will I figure this out?	My experience. For this assignment, research is optional. What do I want to say? Who do I want to say it to?
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Getting Started

Whenever you write—as a student in a composition classroom or a professional in a workplace—you focus on a specific topic. In some instances, you may be asked to address a general theme or a specific topic or issue. For example, your instructor might ask you to respond to an essay you've read for class, or your manager at work might ask you to develop and share plans to improve business or increase sales. Other times, most often in the course of college work, you get to start from scratch and choose a topic purely out of your experience, interest, and curiosity.

So, how do you choose a topic? Where should you start? One place might be this book. The Index of Themes, page T-1, organizes every reading in the text by topic, and the Index of Genres, page G-1, will help you see the relationship between topic choice and genre choice.

The best way to get started on identifying a topic that is meaningful to you is to get your ideas flowing. Following are some ways to do that.

Talk to people. Discuss your topic ideas and questions with classmates, friends, family, and coworkers to find out what others have to say about the topic you're considering. Often, explaining why you're interested in a topic can help you focus. When others ask you to clarify your ideas, you will often discover what you really want to say.

Make a brainstorm list. What do you care most about? Begin by making a list of things you are passionate about, your pet peeves, things you are curious about, things you don't understand, or things you'd like to change about the world. From your initial list, force yourself to double or triple the size of the list. Often the best topic ideas are the less obvious ones—ideas that will come to you when you push yourself to keep listing.

Date: October 21, 2016

Name: Gwen Ganow

Brainstorm List: Ideas for the “Take a Position” Assignment

What issues, ideas, or practices do I care about most? What topics would I want to take a position on?

PASSIONS

Movies

Comic books

Video games

Hiking

Dogs

Camping

PET PEEVES/CURIOSITIES

Why do people hate?

How to respond to hate?

Why do people drive slowly in the left lane?

Should I major in biology?

Why do people toss their beer cans on the ground at concerts?

MORE IDEAS

Superheroes

Good guys save the world

Adventure films

Bacteria: what jobs could I get that deal with bacteria?

What kind of training could police departments implement to improve public relations?

Mind map. Like list making, mind mapping gives you a creative format for sketching out your early ideas about a topic. To begin, write the topic or idea you are exploring in the middle of a blank piece of paper (alternatively, you can use mind-mapping software, some of which is available for free online). As you think of details and related ideas, write them around the central topic, connecting them with lines that indicate their relationships.

Freewriting

If you've identified a general topic area, or some of the ideas you've generated in your conversations and brainstorm lists interest you, try freewriting. The goal is to get your ideas written down without judging what you're writing, or editing yourself, or trying to write beautifully. Experiment by making yourself write nonstop for ten to thirty minutes. As you keep your fingers moving, don't worry about making sense or about readers being confused or impressed. No one is going to read this document but you. When you take away the pressure of producing smooth prose, you may be surprised to see the ideas you generate. We like to refer to this as a "shitty first draft."

Advice for Freewriting

As you begin your rough or exploratory draft, remember that it is just for you. No one else ever needs to see it. Think of your draft not as an organized, perfect piece of writing with a clear purpose, but as a messy opportunity for creativity and experimentation.

Don't worry about a thesis or about being logical or eloquent. Instead, focus on quantity rather than quality. That's right: quantity, not quality. Think of words in the first draft as raw materials. You want as much raw material to work with as possible. Imagine an artist beginning a painting. Would she have only the exact amount of paint she needs to create her piece? What if she changes her mind midway through the painting and wants to use more yellow than red? Wouldn't it make sense for her to begin with extra paint in each color to allow her the flexibility to modify her ideas? Writing and other kinds of composing are similar. Beginning with more words than you need gives you more options. Here are some pointers for getting your first draft written:

1. Set a timer for thirty minutes and force yourself to write for the entire time, not stopping for anything. That means no stopping to reread and correct or to refer to sources or models, and definitely no stopping to check Facebook.
2. Don't stop to correct or edit what is on the page.
3. Write until you run out of time.

Don't worry about grammar, punctuation, spelling, transitions, topic sentences, organization, titles, and so on. Don't even worry about genre or what the finished piece will look or sound like. Once you have your thoughts down, you can think logically about your purpose, audience, and the points you want to convey.

At this stage, if you're putting pressure on yourself to write flawless, beautiful prose, remind yourself of the term *freewrite*. Take a little more pressure off by thinking of Anne Lamott's phrase "shitty first draft." Everybody, including published authors, writes them. (See Anne Lamott's essay in the Reader section of this book, on pp. 522–25.)

Let's circle back to Amy's student Gwen. Earlier in this chapter, we looked at the "Take a Position" assignment that Gwen responded to, followed by her brainstorm. Her thoughts on the assignment and her brainstorm led her to focus on superheroes and social attitudes. What position could she take on the relationship between the heroes and the values and prejudices of the real world? She began with this question:

TOPIC QUESTION FOR "TAKING A POSITION" ASSIGNMENT

To what extent do superheroes reflect real-world values and attitudes?

Gwen then moved from that question to a freewrite.

Guided Reading | Freewrite

Gwen began with some exploratory freewriting, a low-stakes method that allowed her to reflect on her experiences and solidify her thoughts about superheroes and social attitudes.

GWEN'S RHETORICAL SITUATION & CHOICES	GENRE CONVENTIONS
AUDIENCE At this point, Gwen is writing for herself and her instructor, Amy. They'll go over this draft together to try to pin down a direction. Gwen will later identify her additional audiences—her classmates as well as public audiences. RHETORICAL APPEALS Gwen is in exploration mode so is not concerned right now about ethos, logos, and pathos. MODES & MEDIA Gwen e-mailed this Word document to her instructor. PURPOSE Gwen explores possible angles for her project. "To what extent do superheroes reflect real-world values and attitudes?" She lets herself be unfocused as she writes about her fascination with superheroes. After her freewrite, she realizes that she wants to cover how superheroes fight intolerance.	What characterizes a freewrite? ELEMENTS OF THE GENRE A freewrite is characterized by free-form thought and questions. It is a brainstorming tool to use to reflect on your experiences with your topic, to discover what you already know and think about your topic, and to consider what you want to say about it. STYLE Gwen is not worried about style, grammar, or how her freewrite reads. It's not meant to be perfect. Her writing is very casual, as if she's writing in a journal to herself. DESIGN A freewrite is not designed. It's typically a simple document without formatting. SOURCES Gwen does not discuss evidence in this draft, but she could have, depending on her rhetorical situation and whether source material was appropriate for the situation or assignment.

◀ What is the author, Gwen Ganow, doing?

English 121 English Composition

Date: November 1, 2016

Name: Gwen Ganow

Freewrite: Topic for the "Take a Position" Assignment:
Superheroes and Social Attitudes

I've always been fascinated by superheroes. I remember sitting in my bedroom when I was in second grade and paging through a stack of comic books. I became obsessed with them. And my superhero posters, I could stare at them for hours. In a way, superheroes were my first loves.

Man, those superheroes—very, very cool. I loved the power they had.

What kind of power? They faced challenges and obstacles, evil men trying to destroy someone, usually evil men, seldom women. Why? Superheroes protect people. Innocent people. Seems that the city was always the setting—not the suburbs. Why is that?

Regardless of challenges, superheroes win. Why can't they die? What would that mean? Losing hope, maybe. Okay, that's a downer. I need them to win.

Superheroes were giant protectors and a way for me to escape. I'd read at night, even after lights out, wanting to see how the superhero would save the day.

Subjected to prejudice or intolerance—superheroes are often seen as different, as outsiders. It causes social problems for them. They worry that their loved ones will be hurt—like Spider-Man and Mary Jane. The superhero is actually a victim of injustice. Many become superheroes because of injustice in their life, like Batman's parents being murdered.

Superheroes are champions fighting discrimination. They defeat evil powers. How do they do that? I'd like to explore that. Do they fight racial injustice? Are there other forms of intolerance? Other areas of intolerance in life?

CHECKLIST | Getting Started on Your Topic with a Freewrite

Keep the following questions in mind.

RHETORICAL SITUATION & CHOICES

- ☐ **What is my purpose?** What do I want to say—and how do I want to say it? What experiences have shaped my thoughts on this topic?
- ☐ **Who am I composing for?** Who will my audience ultimately be—beyond myself and my instructor and maybe my classmates?
- ☐ **How will I connect with my audience?** How will I establish my authority as a composer (ethos) so that my readers will trust me? What is the most logical way for me to present what I have to say? To what extent will I want to appeal to my audience's emotions? For example, if I want to persuade people to take a certain action, how will I cultivate their enthusiasm?

GENRE CONVENTIONS

- ☐ **As I freewrite, how can I take pressure off myself so I can generate my ideas freely?** I need to remember that freewriting is about quantity over quality. I can refine later.
- ☐ **What do I already know about my topic?** What intrigues me about this topic? What questions do I still have about it?
- ☐ **Based on my experience and thinking so far, what arguments am I familiar with about this topic?** Are there some that resonate for me more than others? Do I have an opinion on this topic?
- ☐ **Is there a way to narrow my topic by time, place, demographics, or something else?** For example, if I write about pets reducing

anxiety, do I focus on therapy dogs (narrow by breed) or the acceptance of therapy animals in the workplace (narrow by place)?
